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The Fifth Tier Adds Nothing You Can Measure

A Taxonomy of Self-Serve Car-Wash Program Names Against Their Bay-Sensor Wash Cycles

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Background

Self-serve car-wash kiosks price four or five named tiers, each promising more than the last. Little is known about how much of that promise is delivered in the bay itself, and how much lives only on the button.

Aims

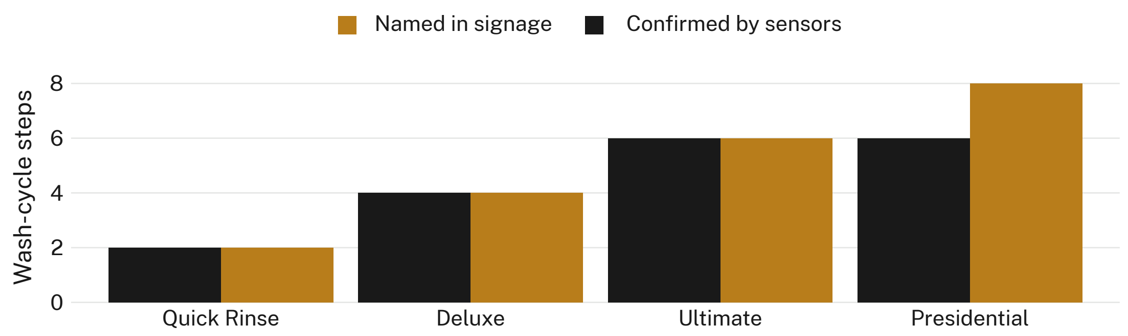
- Catalogue every tier name and claimed inclusion across a chain's payment kiosks
- Log which mechanical steps a bay's own sensors confirm per tier
- Test whether a tier's price rank predicts its confirmed step count

Methods

- 17 sites · one regional self-serve chain · 4–5 tiers per kiosk
- Bay-sensor telemetry (dwell time, foam-arm, undercarriage jet, hot-wax cycle) logged June–Nov 2025
- Signage coded into a 6-category step taxonomy, pre-registered before sensor logs were pulled

Results

Confirmed steps rise sharply from Quick Rinse to Deluxe, then plateau across Ultimate and Presidential at 14 of 17 sites. Price rank keeps climbing regardless.



Sensor logs confirm six wash-cycle steps for both Ultimate and Presidential at 14 of 17 sites (June–Nov 2025), despite signage separating them by two further named inclusions.

Discussion & conclusions

The taxonomy resolves cleanly onto the signage; it stops resolving onto the bay. Above Deluxe, a tier buys a longer dwell time and a costlier button, not a new mechanical step. Next: extending the coding scheme to attended sites, where an operator can add a step a kiosk cannot.

References

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Kiosk signage photographed from the public forecourt only; no vehicle plates retained.

"Presidential and Ultimate share every step but one."

Six confirmed steps at both tiers, 14 of 17 sites, June–Nov 2025.